Guest Speaker #8 Summary: Marcus Wong, Manufacturing Engineer

Marcus Wong is a manufacturing engineer who graduated from SJSU in 2023 with a degree in Engineering Technology, Manufacturing Systems, and went on to pursue an M.S. in Mechanical Engineering at the University of Michigan. His interests are manufacturing and 3D printing. He started at SJSU in Fall 2019 and called his senior project with Professor Vlad the most valuable class in his department, since the program allowed him to experience hands-on work. His career path after SJSU consisted of Comet, OhmniLabs, Microsoft, Tesla, the University of Michigan, and concurrently NSK. He then covered how to be successful once you land your first internship. He talked about the pros and cons of different company sizes and how to plan for a master's degree. On company size, he stated that medium to large companies offer more resources and exposure to new technology and work. However, this also means you have less of an impact on your company, and there is tough competition between coworkers. Smaller companies offer more project opportunities and closer relationships, but are less financially stable and can lead to working longer and harder hours to get all the work completed by the deadlines. He suggested starting at an established company for the organized experience, while searching for isolated, smaller branches of the company to still get that exposure and experience of a startup. This is what he has the opportunity to experience at his time as Microsoft.

Some things I learned about corporate life are that it is important to take initiative and ask questions. You need to get to know your peers and adjust how you talk to them depending on their corporate status and your relationship with them. Secondly, he was very adamant about not being picky about what job you land. Recruiters down the road do not care what your first few jobs were and whether you jump around trying to find a good fit. A job is a job, and the experience is invaluable to you as a recent graduate. Thirdly, perfection is the enemy of progress. He spoke about spending your time effectively and using your time wisely depending on the audience of your work. If your work is for important people within the company, then you obviously want to spend more time on the project. Also, it depends on the company and your position, and whether you are working on prototypes or finished products. Fourthly, if you do plan to pursue an M.S. after your B.S or B.A., start planning early in order to gain recommendation letters and complete all of your research and requirements before they are strictly needed. Finally, he spoke about our major and his major: Engineering Technology. He stated that this major is great for the hands-on experience it provides us compared to the more theoretical engineering majors. However, if you plan to transition into a more theoretical engineering for your M.S., be prepared to take some supplementary community college courses to get yourself up to speed with the math and science level that is expected for that degree.

The key takeaways from this guest speaker were that most of his advice displayed the importance of showing up, asking questions, and being willing to start small and fail over and over in order to learn. Being okay with imperfect work and building relationships with coworkers matters just as much as your individual technical and soft skills. His point about planning for grad school can also be applied to being proactive within school and taking the initiative to complete some other projects, homelabs, etc., and attending seminars and organizational events to grow your social network.